

You said it...



I have been trying to install a Linux distro on my external hard drive, but have failed miserably over the past few months. I have tried out every distro given by you but there has been no positive result. Most devastating was when I unsuccessfully tried Dreamlinux, which had an option of being installed to an external hard drive (as mentioned by Shashwat Pant in the May 09 issue). If possible, please publish an article on installing distros on USB HDDs in the next edition of LFY.

—Anuvrat Parashar,
bhanuvrat@gmail.com

Shashwat replies: Kindly follow the instructions below to get the hard drive booting:

1. Make sure your motherboard supports booting from external devices like USB drives, card readers, etc.
2. Then Enter BIOS-->Advance BIOS Features-->Set First boot device; though the location depends from motherboard to motherboard and the type of BIOS it comes with. You can either try setting the first boot device to the USB-HDD or, in case this option is not available, look for the option "Set Hard Disk Boot Priority" under the same section in the BIOS. Make the attached drive as the primary booting source by slotting it as #1 in the list.
3. Again, under the Advance BIOS section, set the hard disk as the first boot device. Save and exit.
4. Now, if your motherboard supports booting from external drives, you will be able to boot from it if you have installed the distro correctly. I hope this helps you

boot Linux distros from your external hard drive. Happy and persistent booting!

Anuvrat replies: I have been fiddling around a bit with the BIOS, so all that had to be done to set up a boot priority was done perfectly. The installation of Dreamlinux on an external disk took place very well. I had opted for a 10 GB root partition, a 1 GB swap partition, and the rest as a home partition. The MBR was selected to load GRUB, and the installation was run in the absence of the internal hard drive.

When I tried to boot, 'ERROR 22' was what greeted me. And with some other configuration --perhaps with GRUB in the root partition -- the error that showed up was 'BOOTMGR missing'.

I have tried to install many other distros on my external drive in the past few months—for example, Debian Lenny, OpenSolaris 2008.11, Mandriva Spring 2008 and 2009, PCLinuxOS, openSuse 11.1, Ubuntu 8.10 and 9.04. Every time something or the other went wrong and I had to give up, disappointed. I tried my luck with Dreamlinux when I read about the possibility of installing it on an external drive. In case there is some editing to be done with GRUB, then please guide me as I do not know anything about it except selecting it and pressing Enter. It would be very helpful if you could guide me further in my quest to install Dreamlinux successfully on my external drive.

Shashwat: Do let us know how you have installed the other distros? Try installing GRUB either in /dev/sda (or /dev/hda depending on type of hard disk), or create a separate /boot

partition to avoid that error. The Error 22 either means that the partition is missing, corrupted, or the boot list is messed up. Quoting <http://www.gnu.org/software/grub/manual/grub.html>: Error 22 is returned if a partition is requested in the device part of a device or full file name, which isn't on the selected disk.

Try a clean installation and please let me know what happened.



I have been reading LFY since January this year. I had picked up a copy after about five years. Admittedly, I just wanted a Fedora 10 DVD, but when I saw the contents of the issue, I couldn't rest till I had finished it, and I read every single article! Since then I have been a regular reader, and the magazine never lets me down. Kudos to the LFY team! Keep up the good work!!!

I particularly liked some of your regular columns like *A Voyage to the Kernel*, *The Joy of Programming*, and *Programming in Python for Friends and Relations*. I was wondering if you could send me the PDFs of previous issues that featured articles from the above series. I am dying to read them from the beginning.

I have some suggestions for the magazine:

1. Please make sure that the CDs and DVDs you supply are bootable (I am talking about the PC-BSD DVD, bundled with the May 2009 issue). If you are packing multiple distros, you could create multi-boot DVDs. This saves readers the hassle of burning DVDs just for the sake of trying out the distro, and is